Khrushchev suggested that the weapons that he, like Kennedy, never called “nuclear” could be removed, but only as part of a comprehensive agreement on nuclear disarmament. “Under such conditions,” continued Khrushchev, “I think that we would not remove all weapons from Cuba but simply drown them in the vicinity if you were to do the same with your weapons.” Turning the Caribbean into the world’s nuclear dumping ground struck Khrushchev as a mutually beneficial solution. The letter ended with a threat of nuclear war: “But if any aggressor should attack Cuba, in that case the weapons themselves will start firing in retaliation.”[11]

Khrushchev apparently dictated his personal letter late in the day, after the meeting of the Presidium. He had admitted the presence of nuclear weapons to Knox and now implied the same in writing: there were nuclear arms on the island; they were operational and under Soviet control; and they were rigged to go off in the event of an attack on Cuba, leading to Soviet-American conflict and the start of a nuclear war. Khrushchev postponed its dispatch, planning to get approval from the Presidium the following day. He went to bed on October 24 fully resolved to blackmail Kennedy with the use of nuclear weapons in the event of an American invasion of Cuba.

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ON OCTOBER 25, SOVIET NEWSPAPER HEADLINES VERY MUCH reflected Khrushchev’s mood of the previous day. *Izvestiia*, edited by Khrushchev’s son-in-law, Aleksei Adzhubei, published a front-page poem by one of the leading Soviet poets, Nikolai Dorizo, attacking the naval blockade of Cuba and expressing the conviction that it would be broken. “The waves will break the blockade, Cuba / The sun will break the blockade, Cuba / And victory will be yours, Cuba,” read the poem.[12]

Despite the upbeat tone of the Soviet media, for Khrushchev the morning began with bad news. To his official letter protesting the imposition of the blockade, Kennedy responded with a terse telegram that consisted of only two full paragraphs but left no doubt that Khrushchev’s bullying tactics were not working. War or no war, Kennedy was moving